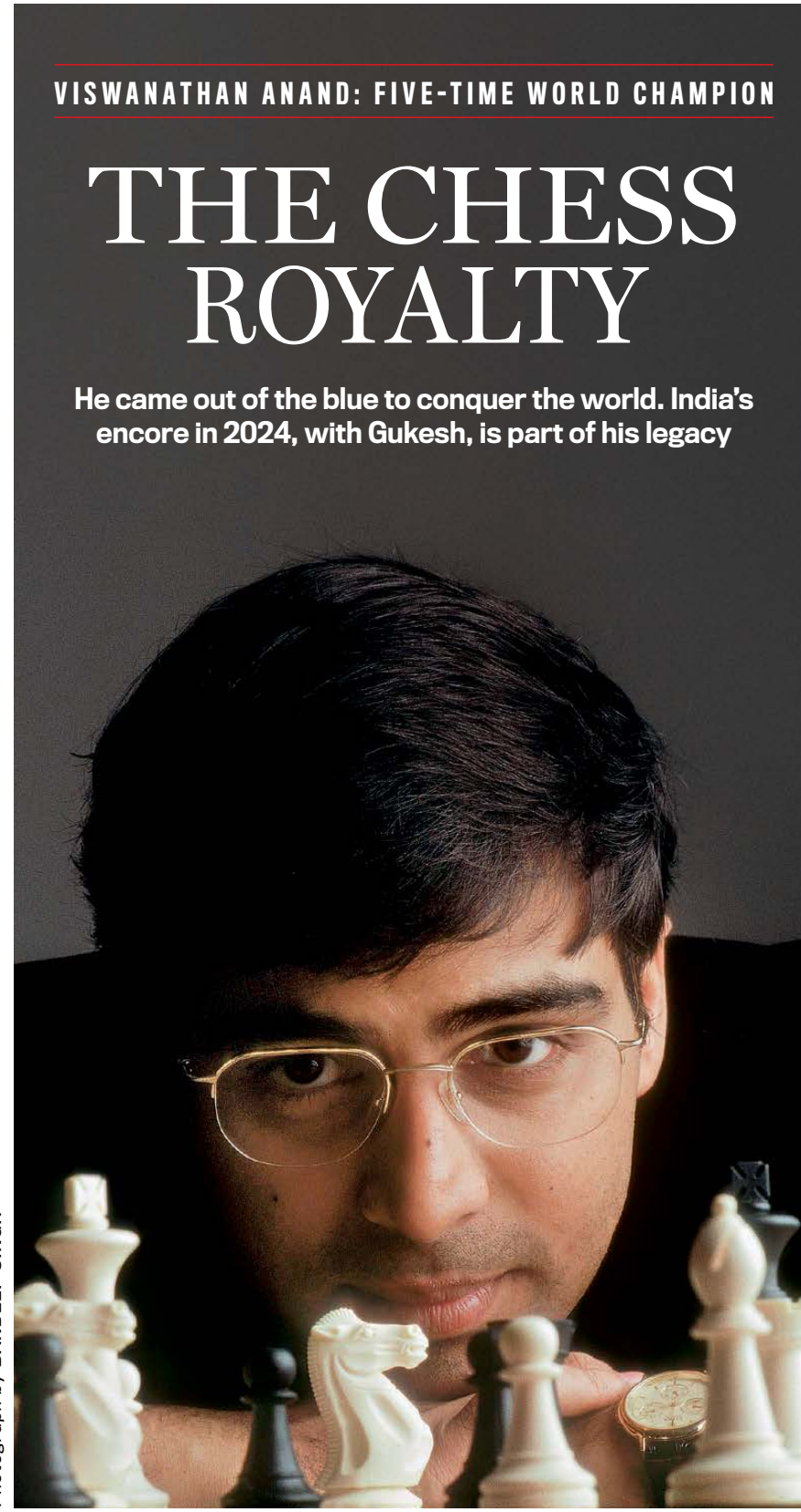
VISWANATHAN ANAND: FIVE-TIME WORLD CHAMPION

THE CHESS ROYALTY

He came out of the blue to conquer the world. India's encore in 2024, with Gukesh, is part of his legacy

BY AMARNATH K. MENON

As 1975 passed, it was not just INDIA TODAY and *Sholay* that were added to the repository of homegrown phenomena with enduring effects over the decades. On one of those Eastmancolor days, a six-year-old boy in Madras asked his mother to teach him a strange game. It had a 'battlefield'—a chequered board with 64 squares—and two medieval standing armies. The charming pieces, squiggly-shaped infantrymen and their sundry *comandantes*, moved in mysterious ways. Diagonal, linear, sudden horse-like pirouetting hops. The most thrilling moment was when a small guy travelled all the way to the other end and transformed into the most powerful piece.... That was to find a literal correlate barely a dozen years later, in 1987, as Viswanathan Anand tore across the entire galaxy of chess to became the world junior champ. He



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

THE FIRST OF MANY
Viswanathan Anand after winning the FIDE World Chess Championship 2000

DID YOU KNOW?

The new world champ Gukesh Dommaraju is one of those Vishy chose to mentor at WestBridge Anand Chess Academy, set up in 2020

85 GRANDMASTERS

Vishy was India's first grandmaster. Today, we have all of 85. India also has 124 International Masters, 23 Woman Grandmasters and 42 Woman International Masters